



Agathe Sorel, *Chronos in Black*, xxxxx

Chronology of events

28th July 1914-11th November 1918

First World War The end of the war saw the dissolution of the Austro-Hungarian Empire

4th June 1929

Treaty of Trianon which regulates the status of the new independent state of Hungary

1920

Numerus Clausus in Hungary restricts entry to universities of Jewish students to 6% of the intake November

1935

Formation of the Arrow Cross Party

9th-10th November 1938

Kristallnacht (Night of Broken Glass): anti-Jewish pogroms in Germany, Austria and the Sudetenland; 200 synagogues destroyed; 7500 Jewish shops looted; 30,000 male Jews sent to concentration camps such as Dachau, Buchenwald and Sachsenhausen

15th November 1938

All Jewish pupils expelled from German schools

1938-1941

Anti-Jewish laws passed in Hungary

1st September 1939

Germany invades Poland

3rd September 1939

Britain and France declare war on Germany

9th April 1940

Germany occupies Denmark and southern Norway

10th May 1940

Germany invades the Netherlands, Belgium, Luxembourg and France

May 1940

Concentration camp established at Auschwitz

October 1941

Establishment of Auschwitz II (Birkenau) for the extermination of Jews. Roma, Sinti, Poles, Soviet Prisoners of War and homosexual men were also murdered there. The greatest number of Jewish victims was Hungarian

7th December 1941

Japanese attack Pearl Harbour

11th December 1941

United States declares war on Japan and Germany

Summer 1942

Deportation of Jews to killing centres from Belgium, Croatia, France, the Netherlands and Poland

Winter 1942

Deportation of Jews to killing centres from Germany, Greece and Norway

May 1944

Adolf Eichmann takes charge of industrial scale murder of Jews in Hungary. 12-14,000 Hungarian Jews deported to Auschwitz each day till 24th July

6th June 1944

D Day – Allied invasion of Normandy

7th October 1944

Revolt by inmates at Auschwitz; one crematorium blown up

15th October 1945

Miklós Horthy tries to announce an armistice in Hungary with the Soviets but is arrested by the German plenipotentiary. The Arrow Cross Party takes over power. Over the next three months, their death squads shoot over 10,000 Jews on the banks of the Danube in Budapest

17th January 1945

Evacuation of Auschwitz; beginning of death marches

27th January 1945

Auschwitz liberated by the Red Army

6th-10th April 1945

Death march of inmates of Buchenwald

18th January 1945

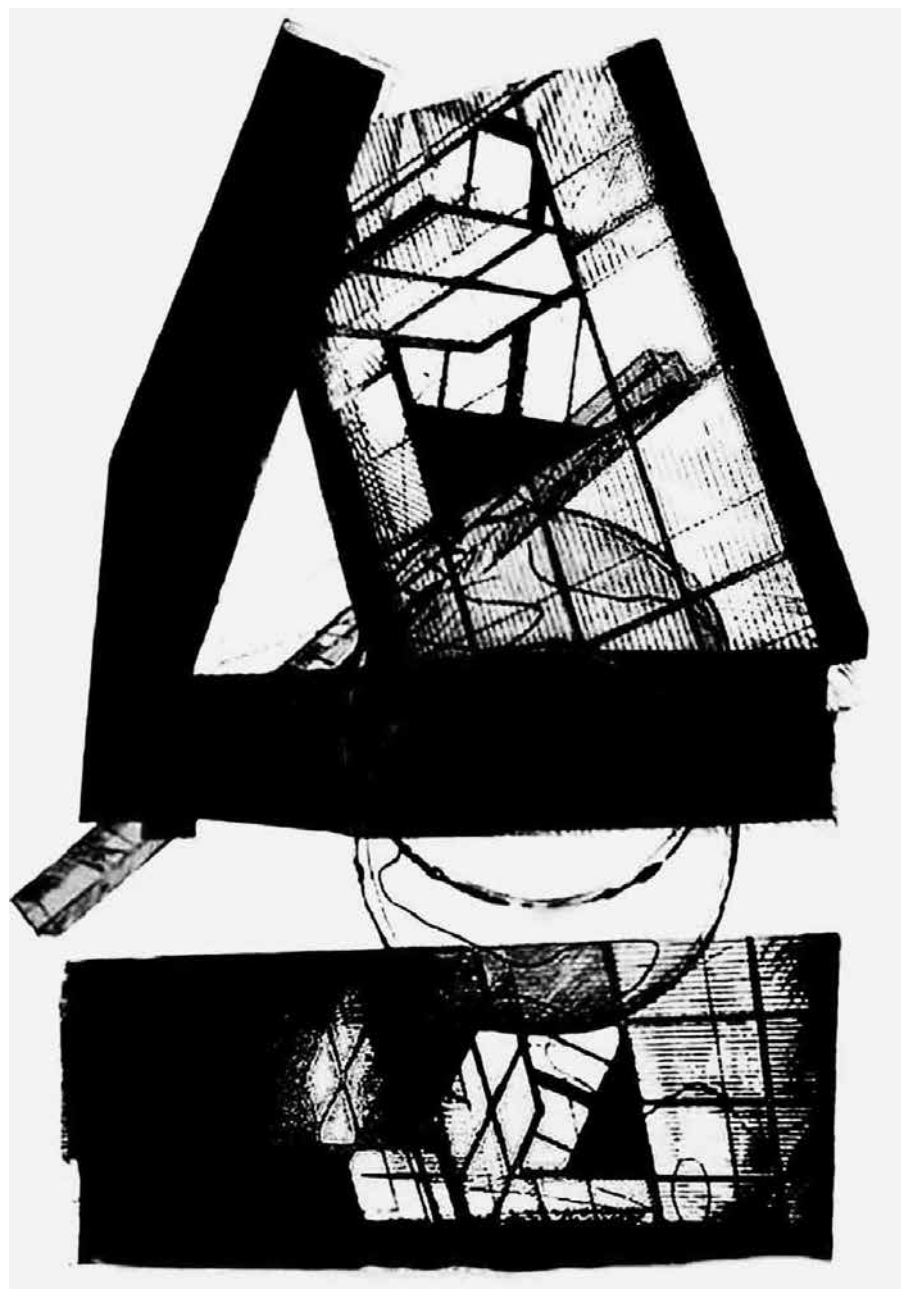
Soviet troops liberate Budapest

30th April 1945

Hitler commits suicide in his bunker in Berlin

8th May 1945

The Resienstadt liberated by the Red Army. Victory for the allies in Europe declared



Acts of Heroism and Defiance

In this section, I pay tribute to those who risked their lives to help Jews escape from the Nazis and sometimes paid with their livelihoods, or even, in the case of Wallenberg who saved me, his life.

Raoul Wallenberg 1912-1947



This Swedish diplomat and businessman saved thousands of Jews in Hungary, among them my parents and me. He was posted to Budapest as a special envoy. There, he issued protective passports and designated buildings as Swedish territory where Jews could stay safely. He was completely fearless.

He died in 1947, killed by the KGB, the Russian secret police, by the order of the Soviet government and quite possibly on the orders of Stalin himself. He was accused of being a double agent acting for the CIA.

He received many posthumous honours and was granted Honorary Citizenship of the United States of America and of Israel. He is commemorated in London with a statue by sculptor Philip Jackson in the renamed Wallenberg Place near Marble Arch.

Sir Nicholas Winton 1909-2015



Nicholas Winton was born in England to German Jewish parents. He worked at the stock exchange, when, after Kristallnacht he was called to Czechoslovakia by a friend who asked for help in Jewish welfare work. Singlehandedly, he found homes for 669 Czech-Jewish children in Britain, organised their transport across Europe and raised the surety money of £50 for each child. This sum would be equivalent to £1500 each today. Most of the parents of these children were killed, but the children grew up in loving homes, many of them achieving distinguished careers and they include Lord Alf Dubs who has recently fought for unaccompanied refugee children to be admitted to this country.

Sir Nicholas Winton's achievements in saving Jewish children were only recognised by the wider world in 1988 after his story was told on the BBC television programme *That's Life*. He was knighted in 2003. <https://youtu.be/B4m-zCcLrDI>

Opposite: Agathe Sorel, *The Dark Satanic Mills*, 1974

Oskar Schindler 1908-1974



Oskar Schindler, a Nazi party member, purchased an enamelware factory in Krakow, Poland which had a workforce of 1750 including over 1000 Jews. Schindler protected his workforce from deportation by offering Nazi officials ever larger bribes and gifts of luxury items he obtained on the black market. By the end of the war, he had spent his entire fortune

on saving lives in this way.

After the war, Schindler was supported by many of those whose lives he had saved. He was named 'Righteous among the Nations' by the Israeli government in 1963 and on his death, was buried on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. His story reached a wider audience first through Thomas Keneally's historical novel *Schindler's Ark*, published in 1982 and then through Steven Spielberg's 1993 film *Schindler's List*.

Giorgio Perlasca 1910-1992



Giorgio Perlasca was an Italian army officer from near Padua, who had a distinguished war record. During the Spanish Civil War, he fought on the side of Franco, receiving in gratitude, a safe conduct for Spanish embassies. During the Second World War, he was working supplying meat to the Italian forces.

When Italy surrendered to the Allies in 1943, he was imprisoned but escaped and went to the Spanish Embassy where he was given Spanish citizenship. He helped the embassy officials to issue letters of protection to Jews and even continued doing so after the rest of the Spanish diplomats had abandoned the embassy. He also kept eight safe houses for Jews to shelter in. He famously rescued two young boys, whom he had been sheltering but had been found, as they were about to board a cattle truck destined for Auschwitz. He confronted the senior German officer in charge showing fake papers and demanding that they should be released. According to Wallenberg, who was also there, this officer was Adolf Eichmann, the notorious brains behind the Final Solution. In all, he saved well over 5000 Jews in this way.

After the war, Perlasca went back to his village and never talked about these heroic deeds even to his family. He was eventually tracked down by the families of those he had saved and his story became known.

Marcel Marceau 1923-2007



Marcel Marceau's entertained audiences around the world for over sixty years as a mime artist. What is less well-known is that he also saved hundreds of Jews during the Holocaust.

Born to a Jewish family in Strasbourg, France in 1923, young Marcel Mangel discovered Charlie Chaplin at age five and became an avid fan. He entertained his friends with Chaplin imitations, and dreamed of starring in silent movies. When Marcel was 16, the Nazis marched into France, and the Jews of Strasbourg had to flee for their lives as Strasbourg was so close to the German border. Marcel fled to Limoges and became involved in the resistance where he made forged identity papers for Jews. He changed his own surname to Marceau.

Masquerading as a scout leader, Marceau led a group of Jewish children dressed as scouts out of France. He told the children he was taking them on an expedition in the Alps, and led them to safety in Switzerland. He made the perilous journey three times, saving hundreds of Jewish children. He was able to avoid detection by entertaining the children through mime.

Marceau's father perished at Auschwitz. He later said, "The people who came back from the camps were never able to talk about it. My name is Mangel. I am Jewish. Perhaps that, unconsciously, contributed towards my choice of silence."

In 2001, Marcel was awarded the Wallenberg Medal for his acts of courage during the Holocaust. <https://youtu.be/uAZLDn8or3M>

Aristide de Sousa Mendes 1885-1954



Aristide de Sousa Mendes was employed by the Portuguese diplomatic service and was posted to many different countries before the Second World War. In 1938, he was posted to Bordeaux as Portuguese Consul-General, with jurisdiction over south-west France. The city was by then inundated by desperate people, many of them Jewish, attempting to escape the Nazis.

De Sousa Mendes disregarded instructions from the Portuguese dictator Salazar that limited those to whom Portuguese transit visas could be issued. He helped all those he was able to, with estimates of those who received visas ranging from several hundred to 30,000. He gave visas to members of the Rothschild family, the Chassidic Rabbi Chaim Kruger as well as to artist Salvador Dalí

whose Russian wife Gala was having difficulties getting a visa.

De Sousa Mendes was recalled to Portugal in late 1940 and demoted for his disobedience. He died in poverty in 1954. His family spent many years trying to clear his name and he was later honoured by the Israeli government as 'Righteous among the Nations' in 1966.

Hiram Bingham IV 1903-1988



Hiram Bingham IV was the son of Hiram Bingham III, the American Senator most famous for having explored the ruins of Machu Picchu. His mother was heiress to the Tiffany and Co fortune. Hiram Bingham IV entered the diplomatic service and in 1939 he was posted to Marseilles as an American Vice consul where he had responsibility for issuing entry visas to the USA. The US government, then neutral, wanted to maintain good relations with Marshall Petain's Vichy regime and actively discouraged its diplomats from helping refugees.

In defiance of these instructions, Harry, as he was known, toured internment camps and attempted to improve conditions. He granted 2500 USA visas to Jews and other dissenters including Marc Chagall, Max Ernst, and Hannah Arendt. He paid some of their expenses out of his own pocket.

In 1941 Washington lost patience with him and posted him first to Portugal and then to Argentina, where he helped to track Nazi war criminals. He left the diplomatic service in 1945 after being passed over for promotion.

Nothing was known about his activities until after his death his son found his letters, documents and photographs recording his actions.

King Christian X of Denmark

Legend has it that after the invasion of Denmark by the Nazis in 1940,



King Christian X of Denmark made the remarkable symbolic gesture of appearing with his entourage and ambassador in full dress uniform, but wearing among all the medals and stripes the yellow Star of David that Jews were forced to wear in other parts of Europe though not in Denmark. Whilst this story has now been shown to be a myth, perhaps invented by Danish Americans wishing to deflect criticism of their country which fell so easily to the Germans, it is true that the King wrote in his diary that if Danish Jews were forced to wear the Yellow Star of David, then all Danes should wear it.

King Christian also helped finance the transport of Danish Jews to unoccupied Sweden in 1943 when they were threatened with deportation. Hitler was powerless facing such united resistance.

This is all true but why did not this happen in Hungary.

Bibliography

- Aboudrar, B.N (2009) *Ici-Bas*. Paris, Gallimard, Paris
- Anissimov, M (2000) *Primo Levi: Tragedy of an Optimist*. New York, Overlook Press
- Bánffy, M (2016) *They were Counted, The Writing on the Wall*. London, Arcadia Books
- Cohen, D (2010) *The Escape of Sigmund Freud*. New York, Overlook Press
- Frankl, Z (1995) *Whirlwind*. London, London, Dillons
- Hoffman, E (1994) *Exit into History*. London, Minerva
- Hoffman E (2008) *Lost in Translation: A Life in a New Language*. New York, Vintage
- Kerr, J (1971) *When Hitler Stole Pink Rabbit*. London, Puffin Books
- Kerr, J (2002) *Bombs on Aunt Dainty*, London, Harper Collins UK
- Kerr, J (1978) *A Small Person Far Away*. London, Puffin Books
- Kertész, I (2004) *Fatelessness*. London, Harvill Secker
- Koestler, A (2019) *Darkness at Noon*, London, Vintage
- Kops, B (1985) *Neither Your Honey Nor Your Sting* London, Harper Collins
- Levi, P (1996) *If This is a Man/The Truce*. New York, Vintage
- Levi, P (2000) *The Periodic Table*. London, Penguin Modern Classics
- Marton, K (2008) *The Great Escape: Nine Jews Who Fled Hitler and Changed the World*. New York, Simon & Schuster
- Marton, K (2011) *Enemies of the People: My Family's Journey to America*. New York, Simon & Schuster
- Nyiri, J (1979) *Streets* London, Wildwood House Ltd
- Nyiri, J (1989) *Battlefields and Playgrounds*. London, Macmillan
- Ohler, N (2017) *Blitzed: Drugs in Nazi Germany*. London, Penguin Books
- Seth, V (2006) *Two Lives*. London, Abacus
- Taylor, A.J.P (1961) *The Origins of the Second World War*, London, Hamish Hamilton
- Zweig S (2011) *The World of Yesterday: Memoirs of a European*. London, Pushkin Press

Acknowledgements

My cousin George Kovacs initially collected the material from my mother's side of the family. This covered almost 200 years from the former Austro-Hungarian monarchy to the present day and included family diaries and correspondence. His mother Klári Kovacs née Biro was still alive to assist him.

My first reader Mel Gooding advised me on both structure and content and I am tremendously grateful for his advice and valuable assistance. He has also curated exhibitions of my work and written about my exhibitions in the past.

I greatly appreciate the advice and constant support of John Reeves, our friend and solicitor who has immense knowledge of the history of Hungary and who acted professionally in many cases of reparations to Holocaust victims or their families.

I am most grateful to Mátyás Sárkozi, distinguished author and BBC World Service correspondent, who sacrificed his time under great pressure of other work, to get the historical facts as well as spelling and structure right. In fact he has done this twice as the work progressed in unforeseen ways. The most important aspect of his tuition was to teach me how to check the facts through different search engines on the internet and other available material. He thought that the cut-off point of the first part should be the 1956 uprising and its immediate aftermath. He thinks that I was very lucky to be present in the most important junction of modern history and in the most relevant geographical locations to have met the extraordinary people I describe.

Eva Hoffmann, distinguished Polish American writer and New York Times book critic who previously visited my studio, advised me on the choice of a publisher; this was a most valuable contribution, which I deeply appreciate.

I am indebted to Ervin Gabor, a friend from Hungary, who embarked on a similar exercise. Much of the factual information in this book came from him as well as continual useful advice, moral support and vigorous encouragement.

I thank my two readers Catherine Meisels and Zelda McCollum who gave invaluable advice on structure, corrected details and gave encouragement when things became upsetting or difficult. Their support and interest has meant a lot to me.

I would like to give full credit to Lizetta Nagy, who helped me describe the situation in Hungary after the Hungarian uprising of 1956 and informed me about events at the Puppet Theatre and the life story of Sándor Levai, which she did with remarkable candour.

I would like to thank Peter Black, Curator of Prints and Drawings at the Hunterian Museum (University of Glasgow) for his continuing interest and practical suggestions throughout this project, which reflected his tremendous knowledge of the subject.

My son Sylvan Sitkey deserves credit for listening to the whole story, when most of the personal details were unfamiliar to him. He finally advised me to be sensible and keep well away from discussions of complex moral issues on social media.

One of the most important people in visualizing this project is our IT engineer and general advisor Peter Ball who through his family history has had a special interest in this story. His role as a technical advisor was recently taken over by computer trouble shooter Jim Fernbank.

I had not previously realized the total change typography has gone through in the digital age, a field which has changed markedly since I was an illustration student in 1958. Tony Cohen offered to collaborate with me and educate me in this new discipline, offering his great experience and realism, which I truly appreciate.

Having looked through the complex history of my past in Hungary as well as my development as an artist in the West, I realized that a foreword or introduction would be vital. After a lot of searching, I remembered an old friend Peter Hacker, a distinguished thinker and author, Emeritus Research Fellow of St. John's College at the University of Oxford, who was a great admirer of Bill Hayter and his work. In the past, we met several times in my studio and his house, where he was surrounded by the most stimulating company, professors of sciences and humanities and doctoral students. He is still very active in these circles and in a mild and unassuming manner, has provided a powerful critique of conventional thinking

on the brain, theories of neuroscience and the freedom of will for which he is universally recognised. Having just met a publishing deadline for a new book, he has provided a wonderful essay for the beginning of this volume. I am deeply touched by his concern and the trouble he has taken to do this. He has commented how important my publication is in the present political and intellectual climate.

Finally my greatest thanks and appreciation goes to my editor Julia Weiner, Senior Lecturer in Art History at Regent University London, who meticulously checked my facts and resolved my problems with chronology and structure. She also has an admirable touch with language and apt at toning down my excesses. She has an extensive knowledge of art through her research and curatorial experience. Her talents extend way beyond her editorial duties.

Agathe Sorel

London June 2019